

How to Decide a Color Palette for a Website

A practical, step-by-step guide from purpose to production

Most color palette mistakes come from starting with a color wheel instead of the site's job. This guide walks through the decision in order: purpose first, functional roles second, accessibility third, and tools last. Tools like Adobe Color are genuinely useful, but only once the first three steps are done — used earlier, they tend to produce a palette that looks nice in isolation but doesn't actually serve the site.

1. Start from purpose, not aesthetics

Before picking a single hex value, answer three questions:

- What is this site for, and what should a visitor feel or do?
- Who is the audience, and what associations do they already carry with certain colors?
- Is there an existing brand identity, competitor landscape, or cultural context to work within or differentiate from?

A checkout page, a children's game, a government form, and a meditation app all need different emotional registers — calm vs. urgent, playful vs. authoritative, trustworthy vs. exciting. The palette should follow from that decision, not the other way around.

2. Define functional color roles before hues

List what the site actually needs colors to do. Most sites need some version of this set:

Role	Purpose
Primary / brand	The dominant identity color — logo, primary buttons, key accents
Secondary	Supporting color for links, secondary actions, highlights
Background / surface	Page background and card/panel surfaces
Text (primary & secondary)	Body copy and muted/supporting copy
Success	Confirmations, correct answers, positive states
Warning	Caution states, non-blocking alerts
Error / danger	Failed actions, incorrect answers, destructive actions
Accent / reward (optional)	Gamification states — XP, streaks, badges, achievements

Naming the role before the hue prevents a common failure: picking a pretty color, then trying to retrofit it into every use case, including ones it was never suited for (e.g. using the brand color for error states)

because nothing else was defined).

3. Choose hues by association, then narrow with a tool

Colors carry pre-existing cultural and psychological associations. Use these as a starting filter before opening any tool:

Hue family	Common association
Blue	Trust, calm, corporate, technology
Green	Growth, success, nature, money (Western contexts)
Red	Urgency, error, passion, appetite
Orange / coral	Energy, warmth, affordability, playfulness
Purple / violet	Creativity, premium, modern, playful-but-distinct
Gold / amber	Reward, achievement, warmth, premium
Teal	Calm-energetic balance, wellness, professional-fresh

Once a direction is chosen, use a tool such as Adobe Color, Coolers, or Paletton to generate harmonious supporting shades — analogous, triadic, or complementary — around that anchor color. This is the right moment to use these tools: narrowing and harmonizing, not deciding the identity from scratch.

4. Check contrast and accessibility before anything else ships

- Body text on background should meet WCAG 2.1 AA (4.5:1 contrast ratio minimum; 3:1 for large text).
- Never rely on color alone to convey meaning (e.g. error state) — pair with icons, text, or shape.
- Bright, saturated accent colors (golds, corals, light pastels) frequently fail as text colors even when they look fine as backgrounds or badges — test every pairing individually.
- If the site supports dark mode, test contrast separately in both modes — brightening a color for a dark background doesn't automatically fix legibility.

Adobe Color's Accessibility Tools panel, or a dedicated checker such as WebAIM's Contrast Checker, can verify this quickly. Do this before the palette is used in any real page, not after.

5. Limit the palette

A working site palette is usually 2–3 core colors, a neutral scale (background/border/text), and a small set of semantic colors (success/warning/error). More than that, and consistency breaks down — each new page invents its own combination instead of reusing a system.

6. Validate against real content and real devices

- View the palette on an actual low-end phone screen, not just a design tool preview — cheaper screens render color and contrast differently.
- Test with real text content, including any non-Latin scripts the site needs to support — stroke weight and density affect legibility differently per script.
- Get a second opinion from someone outside the project — color-blindness affects roughly 1 in 12 men and 1 in 200 women, and an outside eye catches over-familiarity blindness.

Where tools like Adobe Color fit

Task	Good tool
Deciding brand direction / functional roles	Not a tool job — a product/strategy decision
Generating harmonious supporting shades	Adobe Color, Coolors, Paletton
Checking contrast ratios (WCAG)	Adobe Color Accessibility panel, WebAIM Contrast Checker
Simulating color blindness	Coblis, Adobe Color's color-blind simulation view
Exporting to code (CSS variables, ASE)	Adobe Color, Coolors

Quick summary: purpose → functional roles → hue direction by association → tool-assisted harmony and export → contrast check → limit the set → validate on real devices and content.